

NOBLE DREW ALI AND THE MOORISH SCIENCE TEMPLE

Timothy Drew was born in 1886 in North Carolina, a child of ex-slaves. His mother died shortly thereafter leaving him to a cruel aunt who beat him. Later he ran away and joined the Gypsies. One day as he walked alone, he heard a voice say. "If you go I will follow." He tried to ignore it, but the voice kept repeating itself until he finally left the gypsies and sought after knowledge.

He went to Egypt? where he met the last priest of an ancient cult of high Magic who took him to the pyramid of Cheops, led him in blindfolded, and abandoned him. He found his way out unaided and the magus realized he was a potential adept and offered him initiation. He received the name Noble.

In 1913 in Newark, New Jersey he had a dream in which he was ordered to found a religion "for uplifting of fallen mankind" and especially for the "lost-found nation" of American blacks.

He taught that blacks are Asiatics, specifically Moors, descendents of the biblical moabites. West Africa or Morocco was the promised land (like Ethiopia for the Rastafarians). Going back further, he believed his ancestors were Canaanites and that Ham, father of Canaan was present at the building of Solomon's temple. Thus he called his first center of Moorish Science "The Canaanite Temple."

Nobel's prophecy manifested as a book, the Circle 7 Koran. Although apocraphyl in nature about half of it is lifted from The Aquarian Gospel of Jesus the Christ by Levi H. Dowling of Ohio, 1908.

this is still popular and talks about Jesus "lost" years being spent in India till he was 30. This was based on a couple of predecessors, especailly one by a Russian Jew converted to Orthodoxy who claimed to have found a manuscript in a Tibetan Monastery in Ladakh. It has Jesus buried in Kashmir.

He borrowed from other sources, some as yet unknown for his moral guidance section and, the last of the circle 7 deals with the Asiatic origin and history of the Moors.(also taken from a book of that time, The Moorish Empire by Budgett Meakin, 1899)

In Noble's scheme, the dominion of the Moors extended to America and even to Atlanatis. The Moors were stripped of their nationality in 1774 by the white founding fathers of America and thier Moorish identity lost. Noble Drew had come to restore it.

Drew Ali was a "racialist" but not a racist. He called on every nation to "love instead of hate". He was most concerned for his own people but considered that any "Asiatic" had the right to join the Moorish Science Temple--including Chineese and Japanise and even whites as "celts" or "Persians".

There was no atmosphere of racial hatred as there was later with Elijah Mohammed and the Nation of Islam. The emphasis was always on Love, Truth, Peace, Freedom and Justice."

He also emphasized the spiritual individuality and self sufficiency: "You are, each one, a priest, just for yourself." "Allah and man are one." It is an American/sufi reading of Islam.

The Prophet Mohammed is mentioned only once in the "Koran" as the fulfiller of the works of Jesus. He was mainly addressing

a Christian audience and it seemed he knew more of the "Spirit" of Islam than the "real" Islam.

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BACKGROUND OF THE MOORISH TEMPLE

The first "deep" source of Moorish Science is Masonry. Connections between Islam and Freemasonry may go back to the crusades to pacts between the Templers and Ismailis (Assassins). The Freethinkers of the enlightenment held favorable opinions of Islam mainly because it represented the antithesis of Xianity.

The fact is that Islam, however distorted, had in fact moved from East to West and brought about cultural ferment. This is an example of heresy acting as a means of cultural transfer.

In 1877, some Scottish Rite Masons in NY began the shriners, invented a legend, and bestowed the title "noble" on themselves. Later Shriners found this embarrassing and devolved the organization into a charitable fraternity and saved their fezes for parades and costume balls.

During the Great Columbian Exhibition in Chicago in 1893, a world's fair attended by numerous Eastern Religious figures (including Vivekananda), American blacks, claiming initiation from visiting Moslem dignitaries founded the Black Shriners and its sister affiliate, the Daughters of Isis. It seems Noble Drew was involved in this and borrowed a great deal for his temple.

The other major source for Drew Ali's teachings may well be traced to communities of "Moors" existing in America since the 18th century. Some slaves kept their islamic heritage and folkways and thus he could have learned from them.

THE ISHMAELS

In @ 1785 a group of freed and runaway slaves and poor, white indentured servants fled Kentucky and settled on the future site of Indianapolis. they mingled with the Pawnee Indians and took up a nomadic life.

They were known as fine artisans, musicians and dancers, abstainers from alcohol, prcticioners of polygamy, non-Christian and racially integrated.

J. F. Cooper described them in The Prairie (1827) but until recently, literary historians thought he had made them up. They established a cycle of travel but with the white pioneers, who detested them, Eugenics laws were passed with a plan to break up thier families and castrate the males.

In 1907 The Ishmaels reacted by abandoning nomadism and leaving Indiana for Chicago and Detroit and other midwestern cities where they almost vanished.

In 1925, Noble Drew left Newark, NJ for the midwest which he said was "closer to Islam". The Ishmaelites were among Drew Ali's first converts in the area. Chicago was much more hospitable than Newark had been and the Moorish Science temple entered its golden age.

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THE CHICAGO ERA

Upon joining the temple, converts were given new surnames-- Bey or El and told to wear fezzes all the time. Meat, alcohol, and tobacco were forbidden, as were shaving, and the use of cosmetics and hair-straighteners, and morality was encouraged.

Friday worship was quiet and unemotional, unlike many black Christian Churches. Hymns were sung, replacing Christian with Islamic words (Moslem's that old time religion), The Koran was recited and discussed, a sermon given. Men and women prayed seperately thru the holy prophet, Drew Ali.

New temples were opened in major cities thruout the midwest and south. Drew Ali was praised by the press for his community spirit. They even manufactured and sold old Moorish health care products.

The caticism taught that Mecca was the site of Eden, Devil and angel are names for the lower and higher selves. Tlhe devil was made by the Elohim, the seven creative spirits , but in truth, Satan is nothing but "the shadow of our lower selves and will pass away."

Unfortunately, success brought disaster in its wake. Young and fanatical Moors who became problems for the police in various cities. Also, the sects sudden wealth attracted unscrupulous types who acheived high position, milked the faithful and began to conspire against Drew himself.

In 1929 while Drew Ali was away from Chicago, his business manager was killed. Drew was arrested on suspicion that he had ordered the killing. He was also charged with keeping a harem and "ruining a 12 year old girl".

While in Jail, Drew issued a statement to his followers:. . Tho I am now in custody for you and the cause, it is all right and is well for all who still believe. . .I have redeemed you all and you shall be saved, all of you, even with me. . . .remember

my laws and love one another. Prefer not a stranger to thy brother. Love and truth and my peace I leave you all. Peace from your Prophet, Noble Drew Ali."

These were to be his last words to his followers. The trial never took place. Released on bond, the prophet died, whether by police beatings or assassination from within his group is unknown. Whatever the cause, he died a martyr.

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AFTERWARD

The movement split up into sub-sects following various self-proclaimed reincarnations of Drew Ali. Among those who broke away and set up on their own were the famous Daddy Grace, Father Divine, and Elijah Mohammed.

Many M. S. T. branches still survive, and in recent times have increased in membership and activity. In How to Start Your Own Country, E. Strauss mentions a secessionist group in D.C. called the United Moorish Republic.

In the '50's a number of white and black jazz musicians and beatniks founded the Moorish Orthodox Church, which later took part in the psychedelic movement and still operates in several states. There was even a Moorish Zionist Temple of Moorish Jews in Harlem.

One current of Moorish influence leads through Elijah Mohammed to the genius Malcolm X who discovered orthodox Sunni Islam on his hajj to Mecca, renounced racism, and founded the Muslim Mosque, Inc., and to Elijah's son, Wallace, who made the same decision after Malcolm's murder and his father's death.

THE NATION OF ISLAM

The Black Muslims began in Detroit during the depression. The founder, W. D. Fard gathered followers from among the poverty-stricken blacks and organized the Detroit Temple.

Fard's teachings included "The deceptive character of the white man and the glorious history of the black race." Illiterate followers were taught to read so they could read for themselves the history of their great race.

Fard wrote 2 manuals which are now the basic documents for the movement: "The secret Ritual of the Nation of Islam" and "The Teaching for the Lost Found Nation of Islam in a Mathematical Way."

Fard established the ritual and worship of the temple and founded the Univ. of Islam to provide elementary and secondary education. The "Fruit of Islam", a paramilitary organization for men, was established to deal with unbelievers. Members were taught military tactics, including the use of weapons.

As the movement developed, Fard established a hierarchy under a minister of Islam, ELIJAH MUHAMMED (who had originally been with Noble Drew Ali). Upon Fard's disappearance in June 1934, Elijah Muhammed ran into difficulty with the moderate element of the movement which gained control of the Detroit Temple.

Elijah moved to Chicago and took charge of Temple No. 2. There he began to reshape the movement and make it more militant. Through the teachings of Elijah, Fard was identified with Allah, which made it possible for prayer and sacrifice to be made to

him. Elijah assumed the titles "Prophet" and "Messenger of Allah."

Under Elijah Mohammed, the movement gained international prominence. Mosques were started in most major cities of the U.S. Schools, apartment complexes, stores, and farms owned by the Nation of Islam came to be commonplace. They published 2 periodicals, "Muhammed Speaks" and the "Balalian News", which came to be read by Americans of all races.

The Muslims have had phenomenal success with converting convicts, criminals and dope users. An excellent example of this transformation is the life of Malcolm Little, better known as Malcolm X.

There is a strict morality among Muslims. a devout member must follow certain things including prayer 5 times a day, before prayer, proper ablution must be made. Cleanliness of body and spirit are essential. Dietary laws are rigidly enforced, fasting is encouraged (in Ramadan, its mandatory), tobacco and alcohol are forbidden and there is a strict sexual code.

Traditionally, the Nation of Islam has taught that Christianity is a white religion and that it is a disgrace for blacks to call themselves Christians.

Central to the traditional teachings are: 1) the black man has a manifest destiny, 2) Whites are the personification of evil, a hindrance to black freedom and moral development., 3) The original man was black, 4) there is a divinity in Blackness and 5) the white race was created by a black scientist (Yakub) who had rebelled against Allah.

UP TO DATE

Upon the death of Elijah Muhammad in February, 1975, his son Wallace D. Muhammad assumed the spiritual leadership of the movement and took the title of Imam.

The most significant of the changes he introduced involves the attitude toward whites, who are now permitted to become members. Under this leader the movement assumed the title "The World Community of al-Islam in the West."

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Simon Magus

"All those who in any way corrupt the truth, and harm the teaching of the church, are the disciples and successors of Simon Magus of Samaria...They put forth, indeed, the name of Jesus Christ as a kind of lure, but in many ways they introduce the impieties of Simon...spreading to their hearers the bitter and malignant poison of the great serpent (Satan), the great author of apostasy." - Irenaeus, *Libros Quinque Adversus Haereses*

"Gnostic motifs were already felt in Christian circles in the Age of the Apostles. Early church tradition attributes the rise of Gnosticism to Simon Magus, briefly mentioned in Acts 8:9-24. - Harold O.J. Brown, *Heresies*

"But there was a man named Simon who had previously practiced magic in the city and amazed the nation of Samaria, saying that he himself was somebody great. They all gave heed to him, from the least to the greatest, saying, 'This man is that power of God which is called Great'. And they gave heed to him, because for a long time he had amazed them with his magic." "Now when Simon saw that the Spirit was given through the laying on of the apostles' hands, he offered them money, saying, 'Give me also this power, that any one on whom I lay my hands may receive the Holy Spirit.' But Peter said to him, 'Your silver perish with you, because you thought you could obtain the gift of God with money!' " - Acts 8:9-11, 18-20

His attempt to purchase the gift of the Holy spirit gives us the expression 'simony' for the offense of buying and selling spiritual offices. According to the account in Acts, Simon repented. Later traditions tell us that he went to Rome, where he competed with the Apostle Peter and founded a gnostic sect. The second-century Christian writer Hegesippus, by contrast, tells that the gnostic movement preceded the ministry of Christ in Palestine. Gnosticism was a byproduct of 'seven Jewish heresies', some of them involving gnostic currents."

"The first two teachers to propagate gnostic ideas within Christian circles were Simon and his successor Menander. Unlike later and more famous representatives of Gnosticism, both Simon and Menander claimed divinity for themselves. According to Acts 8:9-11, Simon called himself the 'great power of God'. Simon "met a certain Helena in a brothel in Tyre and discovered that she was a reincarnation of the primordial Ennoia ('Indwelling Mind'), the first conception of the spirit of God. As Ennoia she generated angelic powers, some of which rebelled against god, captured her, and imprisoned her in a mortal body. Reincarnated many times, she was one Helen of Troy...She is the lost sheep of Jesus' parable (Matthew 18:10-14). To save her, the highest God himself appeared in Simon. Characteristically, Simon taught that the Old Testament was the revelation of malicious angels, and hence oppressive. To believe in him was to be free from its bondage." - Harold O.J. Brown, *Heresies*

"In imitation of their master, Simon's disciples seem to have repeated, in their wilder moments, that one

MARY MAGDALENE

Biblical: Unlike Mary, Jesus mother, who is mentioned only 7 times in the canonical texts, even counting the parallels, Mary Magdalene is mentioned 14 times in as many verses. Most of these are in the crucifixion/resurrection stories.

Luke 8 is the one exception where she is named as the one from whom seven demons were cast out. Nowhere is it said she was a prostitute.

Mark, the oldest gospel dating from around 70 AD, records that she was the first to see Jesus risen and that the men didn't believe her. Matthew tells the same story with embellishment.

It is Luke that speaks of MM earlier as one of the women who followed Jesus after he cast out 7 devils and that she and the other women ministered to and supported Jesus financially and otherwise.

The three synoptic gospels (Mark, Matt. and Luke) pretty much agree on the events surrounding the resurrection with minor variations. The one sure thing is that it was Mary Magdalene (and according to Luke) other women who first saw Jesus raised and that the male disciples didn't believe them.

John's gospel: records that the women were at the cross and that "on the first day of the week" it was MM who came and discovered the stone rolled away and then returns to the disciples reporting that the Lord had been taken away.

Peter and the "beloved disciple" race to the tomb where it is reported that the beloved disciple was the first to believe.

Mary is the first to actually see Jesus in the garden. These accounts are all the gospels record about MM. On Pentecost, it is reported there were about 120 people present, including Jesus mother, but not whether MM was there.

What is clear is that MM is considered very important as a witness to, believed or not, to the resurrection. sometimes called "an apostle to the apostles." or the first apostle.

MARY MAGDALENE

Later Christianity:

Later interpreters increasingly reduced the importance of MM and the other women in favor of Peter.

In the 6th century, MM was recreated as an entirely different character to serve the purposes of the ecclesiastical hierarchy. This refashioning by the early church fathers has distorted our view of MM and the other women.

MM was particularly a threat since she of all the other women, is not designated as being attached to some male--husband, king, etc. she alone is identified by her place of birth, a village on the N.W. bank of the sea of Galilee, that is, she is an independent woman and implies she had some wealth to be able to support Jesus.

The later fathers identified the seven devils with sin, which was never done by the bible. It served the purpose for the priests that practiced celibacy as the ideal to make MM, chief female disciple, and beloved friend of Christ, transformed into a penitent whore.

It was pope Gregory the Great (540-604) who gave the coup de tat to MM by settling the question declaring MM, Mary of Bethany, and the sinner in Luke were one in the same person. Their only similarity was an association with anointing Jesus.

This occurred in 590 and interestingly enough was at a time that the cult of the Virgin Mary, Jesus' mother, was gaining ground especially with all the new converts coming into the church from the pagans (ie; those who lived out in the countryside.)

MARY MAGDALENE

MM in the Gnostic tradition:

Another reason for Gregory's demotion of Mary Magdalene was the fact that to the Gnostic groups she was the beloved disciple, the one who understood what Jesus was really saying.

when many of these gospels were found in 1945 at Nag Hammadi, where they had been buried by gnostic christians around 400 AD, it really illuminated what we now see as gnostic understanding of salvation, which is one is saved by knowledge.

in many of the gnostic gospels: Phillip, the Pistis Sophia, the gospel of Thomas, and the gospel of Mary she is seen as the most prominent disciple, visionary, mediatrix and messenger of secret revelations. Even the gospel of Peter, one of the earliest accounts of the passion and resurrection apart from the canonical gospels, described her as a "disciple of the Lord."

there is no reference to her as a sinner or a prostitute but she is Mariam, the "woman who knew the All" who "reveals the greatness of the revealer".

In the Gospel of Phillip she is the most important of three women "who were always with the Lord" and the one who "is called his companion"

In "the Gospel of Mary" after Jesus is ascended, the disciples are afraid and it is Mary who takes the initiative and consoles them saying: "Do not mourn or grieve. . .for his grace will be with you all and will defend you. Let us rather praise his greatness for he prepared us and made us into men." (meaning spiritual rather than matter).

From here on she appears to be in charge of the disciples with her authority deriving from her closeness to Jesus, which even Peter acknowledges, ~~saying~~:

~~not, nor have we heard of them."~~

She tells them that she she will impart what is hidden to them. Her function here is to relate the visionary aspect of Gnosticism, one of the elements soundly condemned by the "orthodox church" represented by Peter.

Much of the Gospel of Mary is missing but when she finishes describing the soul's journey thru the spheres, both Peter and Andrew refuse to believe her, peter doing an about face and is unable to credit that Jesus would have spoken with a woman privately and not openly to the male disciples.

Levi, the tax collector, comes to her rescue and chews out Peter saying he is always irate and contending against women as an adversary. He says that if the saviour has made her worthy, who are you to reject her?.

to conclude, the gnostic gospels were written between the late first and forth centuries against the backdrop of the church becoming institutionalized with a male heirarchy of bishops, priests and deacons claiming authority directly from the apostles (male, that is).

among the gnostics no such heirarchy existed and there was no discrimination based on gender. All were equal and all might function as bishop, pirst or prophet. This amazed the early church fathers, like Tertullian.

After Constantine, and especially after Theodocius made the church the ONLY legal religion of the empire in 383, most of the gnostic writings were either destroyed or hidden away, not to be found again till this century.

PHILOSOPHERS:

There were not many Jewish philosophers in the sense we think of philosophy. Very few used Greek philosophical ideas and terms, even tho the rabbis were acquainted with these ideas, especially those of the Stoics. They were not familiar with "formal" philosophy.

In fact the rabbis used the word "ECPICUREAN" to mean a heretic in general, rather than one who embraces Epicurus' doctrines.

One modern historian of philosophy stated that he was unable to discover a single Greek philosophical term in rabbinic biblical quotations for support of their views. They totally rejected the allegorical method of interpreting scripture and were very circumspect in describing God.

Thus, there are only 2 philosophers who were ever deemed "heretical" and of those, only one who was actually officially excommunicated within Judaism.

LEVI BEN GERSHOM

The first I want to discuss is Levi Ben Gershom, a 14th century thinker. Very little is known about his life except he lived in Avignon, France for a while and maintained relations with some of the most important Christians of his day.

His scientific works dealt with arithmetic, geometry, trigaonmatry and astronomy. His contributions to mediéval astronomy and astronomical equipment became particularly well known. He was a talmudist and liturgist of some importance.

He discussed, in his numerous Biblical commentaries such diverse questions as the problem of providence, miracles, and the Messiah. From each book of the Bible he extracts the ethical, philosophical and religious teachings that may be gleaned from the text.

THE PHILOSOPHERS

Levi attempts to reconstitute the HALAKHAH rationally, basing himself on nine logical principles which he substitutes for the traditional 13 hermeneutical rules and condemning allegorical interpretations.

He writes commentaries on Averroes, an Islamic Aristotilian philosopher, thru whom he learned Aristotle. He attempts to correct their views in his commentaries.

HIS PHILOSOPHY;

Levi's major work, *Sefer Milhamot Adonai*, or The Book of the Wars of the Lord, written between 1317 and 1329. In it he treats problems he feels have not received a satisfactory solution by preceeding philosophers, including Moses Maimonides.

The work is repetitive, for he quotes the works of those he is going to refute and then enumerates the arguments that support and disprove their theses and, finally, he expounds his own theory.

DEMONSTRATING THE EXISTENCE OF GOD:

Levi rejects the Aristotilian view that God is the "Prime Mover". In its place he presents a proof based on the orderly processes existing in the world, the argument from design. Thus the regularity of the world is proof of an intelligence at work.

It can be seen that the celestial and terrestrial worlds form an ordered, unitary whole and this requires that there exists a supreme being which produces and knows this order. This being is God.

Like the mystics (and unlike Maimonides) Levi maintains that it is possible to ascribe positive attributes to God without reducing or changing his absolute unity and simplicity.

THE PHILOSOPHERS

PREDESTINATION:

Levi teaches that man may have a certain positive knowledge of God based on the observation of His actions. The essential action of God is THINKING and, consequently the producing of all forms. All the attributes that man recognizes in his own form are just so many attributes of God. ^{no} By means of a knowledge that is neither temporal or changing, God eternally perceives the general law of the universe. God is aware of the fate that awaits all individuals insofar as they are distributed in groups subject to the same celestial determinism that governs all the conditions of humans. However this may cause misfortune and thus God has accorded humans freedom which allows them to liberate themselves from the shackles of determinism.

An individual who makes use of his freedom is no longer subject to the universal law known by God. But, God's knowledge always remains true, since the author of the free act is no longer included in the necessary and universal proposition thought by God.

God's knowledge embraces all the events of this world, with the exception of free acts that cannot be predicted by any type of knowledge. Levi is convinced he has solved the problem of two contradictory fundamental principles of the Bible: divine omniscience and the freedom of the human will.

In spite of all the harmful effects of determinism, Levi upholds the belief that the true good which is specifically human is the immortality of the soul. It is this immortality, proportioned according to one's moral rectitude and intellectual perfection, that constitutes the actual recompense of God.

God has furnished humans with a practical intellect from which they learn the art of self-preservation, and a speculative intellect which permits one to perceive the truth and to achieve immortality.

THE PHILOSOPHERS

PROPHECY AND THE COVENANT

^{no}Levi, naturally enough, extends providence to the Children of Israel, chosen by God thru his covenant with the Patriarchs. thus, prophecy is a kind of revelation that is superior to all other types of revelation, and differs from them not in degree but in nature. ^{x es}The PROPHET must be a preeminent philosopher who grasps the general laws governing changes in the world. by means of the imagination, the prophet applies this knowledge to the situation of the individual or community, announcing the good or evil events that may befall these as a result of the operation of the laws of nature.

^{no}Unlike Maimonides, who believed that any miracles were built into the laws of nature at the time of creation, Levi maintains that a miracle is produced at a particular time and place and that it occurs when the "miracle worker" suspends normal, natural law, since it no longer applies to certain circumstances.

However, since the miracle worker only has ability to work a miracle here on earth, then the sun did not really stand at the order of Joshua and the victory at Gibeon was attained during the short lapse of time when the sun seemingly stood at its zenith.

^{es}MOSES, the greatest of all prophets, gave Israel the Torah which aims to help the children of Israel attain the moral and intellectual perfection which makes immortality possible for them.

The purpose of most of the commandments is to remove materialistic tendencies and teach the existence of forms. The Torah has also revealed certain metaphysical truths that the philosophers have never been able to deduce, namely, the creation of the world and the immortality of the soul.

LEVI'S ESCHATOLOGY or the study of the end of time is based on a tradition that there are two messiahs.

THE PHILOSOPHERS

After the Messiah son of Joseph dies, having been assassinated, the Messiah son of David will appear. He will be greater than Moses, not because he will give a new Torah, but because he will accomplish a miracle greater than those of Moses: The resurrection of the dead, an event which will convert all peoples of the earth to the true religion. He predicts the coming of the messiah in the year 1358. During the messianic times the world will follow its usual pattern, men will die as before, but the earth will be filled with knowledge of God and human liberty will be utilized for good ends.

VIEWS ON LEVI BEN GERSHOM:

On account of his boldness and extreme rationalism the suspicion of heresy was fastened to him and Levi became the subject of virulent attacks. Certain of his doctrines became the object of harsh criticism.

His major work, Wars against the Lord was severely criticized by several Rabbis, even tho Levi himself was recognized as a great Talmudist. It was maintained that it is prohibited to accept certain of his theories.

However, even the most vehement critics of Levi, who very often did not understand his real thought, did not hesitate to borrow some of his ideas and his influence continued to exert itself even as late as the 19th century.

From the modern vantage point he can be seen to have been the most ardent rationalist in the medieval Jewish tradition who was more willing to accept the implications of his basic Aristotelian system than any of his medieval contemporaries.¹

What if Fundamentalism

I've been asked to "explain" the reason so many religious groups in our world seem to defy reason, seem to disdain science, and in general, want nothing to do with modern ways of thinking. This phenomena is not the belief of only one religion. All three monotheistic faiths, Judaism, Christianity and Islam, share this to a greater or lesser extent.

In this presentation I am indebted to a writer, Bruce B. Lawrence whose book "Defenders of God: The Fundamentalist revolt against the modern age" forms the basis of this lecture. Since it was published in 1989, I have updated many of the ideas from several news sources.

Because of its common usage, I will use the term "Fundamentalism" to cover this understanding. I will define fundamentalism as "the affirmation of religious authority as holistic and absolute, admitting of neither criticism nor reduction". It is expressed thru the collective demand of the faith community that specific creedal and ethical dictates derived from scripture be publicly recognized and legally enforced. Remove scripture and you no longer have fundamentalism but some other non-religious social movement. Fundamentalism is an IDEOLOGY NOT A THEOLOGY.

Fundamentalists do not deny or disregard the modern age. They protest as moderns against what they see as the heresies of the modern age.

So what is Modernism? I will define it as the search for individual autonomy driven by a set of socially encoded values emphasizing change over continuity; quantity over quality; efficient production, power, and profit

over sympathy for traditional values or vocations, in both the public and private spheres.

At its utopian extreme, it enthrones one economic strategy, consumer-oriented capitalism, as the surest means to technological progress that will also eliminate social unrest and physical discomfort.

The word Fundamentalist in English is linked to turn of the 20th century protestant Christianity, yet fundamentalism has become cross creedal and multicultural. It is as intrinsic and inevitable to Israeli ultra conservatives and sunni or Shia Muslims as it is to american protestants.

Who are they? they see themselves as the last ditch defenders of God.

Fundamentalism has been called the only new heresy. This is because without the modern world there are no fundamentalists, just as there are no modernists. The identity of fundamentalism, both as a psychological mindset and as an historical movement, is shaped by the modern world..

Either way, one cannot speak of premodern fundamentalists. Thus, the timeline for discovering, describing, assessing and explaining fundamentalists depends upon the modern way of seeing reality, for fundamentalists are a product of the modern world.

The groups we are talking about are caught in a peculiar tension: they accept the benefits of the modern world, often thriving thru their use of technology, while explicitly rejecting modernism as an ideological framework. They are moderns but not modernists.

What are fundamentalists reacting against? In a word, the Enlightenment. The Enlightenment is the declared enemy, for it undergirds

the modern world. Not only science, which is seen as part of the enemy, but also the modern study of religion.

For virtually all fundamentalists, the three thinkers who are most hated are Darwin, Freud and Marx, but particularly Darwin.

Because the modern world is now global, so is fundamentalism. It is coextensive with our world. It will change, adapting to new circumstances, but it will not disappear. It seems neither scholars nor journalists have really grasped the larger context within which fundamentalism must be viewed.

Fundamentalism is a series of parallel socioreligious movements in the modern world that accept the instrumental benefits of the modern world but NOT its values.

All fundamentalists, whatever their faith, embrace their own canon of scriptural authority as self-conscious advocates of anti-modern values. Fundamentalist loyalty is hatred of the modern value agenda.

The single most consistent denominator for fundamentalists of all three monotheistic faiths is opposition to all those individuals or institutions that advocate Enlightenment values and wave the banner of secularism or modernism.

Nothing has defined the tone of fundamentalist rhetoric as much as the hatred, and also the FEAR, of Modernism.

Part of the modern age has been the rise of Nationalism. The one thing nationalism and fundamentalism have in common is they are Universalist in nature.

They not only incorporate universal norms, but they strain for universal compliance with those norms. This has forced the monotheistic traditions to weigh their own survival in the public arena.

Thus, separation of church and state might be better termed the preservation of church (or synagogue, or mosque) from state.

Nationalism, even in religious guise (ex: the tea party) pushes up against the limits of religious norms. Nationalists are pitted against religion, and it is the fundamentalists who have understood the high stakes in this struggle.

All three monotheistic religions face the same question vis a vis nationalism:.. How can believers preserve their symbolic identity within a public order that is structurally anti-religious? These are not mere contraries, they are genuine contradictions and the outcome has not been decided.

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A LOOK AT ALL THREE FAITHS

Fundamentalism as a religious ideology is defined by its unremitting opposition to nationalism as the most tenacious ideology of the technical age. It is a battle of ideologies that is at work here tho the markings are different for each monotheistic tradition. To how that plays out in each of the three faiths I will not turn.

Protestant Christianity

The position of Protestant Christianity is at once the most moderate and the most ambivalent. Protestant Fundamentalists succeeded in America because of the elective affinity between them and their fellow citizens.

There is a tacit congruity between the scripturally mandated faith of fundamentalists and the constitutionally sanctioned ethos of the majority of Americans.

Together they forged the dominant value system of middle America. Henry May described it as Progressive Protestant Patriotism or PPP. Progressive because it believes in the forward march of history towards some shadowy utopia; Protestant because it accepts, to some degree, the separation of church and state, with the right to practice one's own faith or even to deny all faith as a "God-given right"; and patriotic because it was only in the U.S. that the optimal expression of innate human dispositions can flourish.

The old bumper sticker, "America, Love it or leave it" echos the most extreme version of this view. Many American fundamentalists exalt territorial aspirations to the level of a universalist mandate, for instance on foreign policy issues that involve Israel.

Yet many of these protestant fundamentalists are at odds with their fellow citizens. They see a point of tension between the demands of faith and the exercise of public authority. They would like to compel all Americans to adopt their interpretation of the Constitution.

They have often tried , as for example, with prohibition, to bring about the changes they desire or to change the court decisions they

oppose (for ex: roe v wade) but they have never tried to undermine the peculiarly American system of governance.

While they have enjoyed only slight success in reshaping the public sphere of American life, all their efforts are exerted WITHIN rather than AGAINST the framework of democratic institutions. They want to replace one set of laws with another, one policy with another but not abandon or subvert the political arena, only redirect it..

The one major exception to this is a group called THE CHRISTIAN RECONSTRUCTIONIST MOVEMENT. Coming originally out of the Calvinistic tradition (presbyterian) it crosses all denominational lines, with adherents in most conservative denominations. It believes all the 613 laws given to Moses are binding on people of all nations, cultures and religions forever, except for those that have been modified by further revelation.

It is a political movement to convert the U.S and eventually, the whole world, into a theocracy in which dissenters, adulterers, sexually active homosexuals, witches, sorcerers, etc. would be exterminated by stoning.

JUDAISM

While Protestant fundamentalists remain both progressive and patriotic, with this exception, and standing out for their relative moderation with respect for the political process, Jewish and Islamic fundamentalists have not experienced the development of their communities in tandem with the modern age..

Their situation reflects the growing disparity between the monotheistic traditions as the Technical age advances. They have not been equally privileged in finding a subordinate place within the new order symbolized above all by the power of the nation state.

Jewish Fundamentalists have to grapple with modernism in the form of one of the most successful of all nationalist ideologies, ZIONISM, which came out of the liberal Reform movement started in Germany in the early 19th century.

Tho originally opposing the zionist movement, the Orthodox now are attempting to control marriage and conversions in Israel.

There are several different ultra conservative movements in Israel today: Neturei Karta, Gush Emunim and the Kach party, related to Rabbi Meir Kahane.

It was Hasidism which arose in the Eastern Europe in the early 18th century that provided the spiritual model for Jewish Fundamentalism. With the advent of Hasidism (which simply means pious ones) the REBBE took the place of both the Torah and the scholars. He personified the Torah.

NETUREI KARTA has accommodated to it by remaining in the heart of the state and opposing its persistent efforts to develop a civil religion. Instead of compliance with the requirements of a modern nation-state, they have proposed a strict attention to traditional observances within their confines.

Gush Emunim, followers of Rabbi Abraham Isaac Kook, believes that only when the Jews retake all the land David once had for Israel will the Messiah come. These are the folks trying to settle everywhere, no matter if

its Palistinean land or not. Neturei Karta and Gush Emunim are highly atagonistic to each other.

However, these ultra orthodox have slowly gained more power over the years. The Ultra orthodox jews are the fastest growing sector in Israel, often holding the balance of power in coalition governments and open strains between the more liberal community and the orthodox are far more common.

A few weeks ago, American Jews and Israeli Jewish leaders held a conference trying to iron out their differences but to no avail. the two communities are at odds over everything from religious rituals to gender roles.

Despite the secular majority, ultra-orthodox rabbis strictly govern Jewish practices such as weddings, burials and conversions. The Ultra-Orthodox only allow them for those who meet orthodox definitions of a Jew. Any Jew can become a citizen but once in Israel they find they can't get married or have a jewish burial.

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ISLAM

It is important to remember that Christian and Jewish fundamentalists differ markedly from Islam in their interpretation of nationalism. For most of them it was the benefits of the modern age that colored their reaction to nationalism.

Both America and Israel are contained in a geographic area. However, the opposite is true of Islam. Tho Islamic expansion was limited to the afro- Eurasian world it was a vast domain.

Within its vast and disparate parts, Muslim elites had enjoyed political power and global preeminence for more than a thousand years, till the advent of the technical age.

European colonialism challenged the indigenous politics and agents created their own elite counterparts in the once proud Muslim empires. Even with the end of colonialism, the values persisted.

Thus 20th century nationalism produced a cleavage of enormous magnitude, both between Muslims and the dominant culture of Western Europe and also between Muslims who openly accommodated to western values and those who seemed to oppose them.

Since both the modernizers and their opponents tended to be the urban elites, neither group expressed the fears or hopes of the majority who were mostly rural and illiterate.

The problem is that these Islamic countries have been straightjacketed into an imposed system of government and cannot adapt it to their own values. In theory these should have become nations when they won their independence, but instead they adopted the rubric of statehood without the substance of nationhood.

The Muslim experience is immensely complicated by the fact that Islam, like Judaism, stakes out claims to be a holistic ideology, competent to address every activity of life and every sphere of human society.

Even though Islam claims to be universal, nationalism arising against European and other Islamic countries meant that each country saw themselves as "sacred" over against all others, even other Muslim countries.

Thus nationalism wedded to patriotism suggests that the only ideal worthy of pursuit is territorial or, even more narrowly, racial. Both appeals lead their constituents to be at heart "anti-religious".

Just as European nationalism rang the death knell for any hope of a "Holy Roman Empire" in Europe, so its echo response among arabs and asians precluded any ultimate success for a pan-Islamic movement.

Islamic fundamentalism thus began as a reaction to the dramatic price increases by OPEC in 1973. This produced regional revolution of expectations and further separated the elite from the masses. The disparity between the so called "first world" countries for whom the oil was being produced and the still third world countries that produced it was very visible. Beginning in the 70's a compensatory reaction set in with government sponsored "Islamization" programs to build pride.

this did not erase the underlying problem: the sense of exclusion from the major issues and the ongoing dramas of the technical age felt by Muslim elites and non-elites alike.

In 1979 the takeover in Iran and the little publicized take over of the mosque in Mecca at the same time, signaled more than the beginning of a new islamic century. It also signaled the possibility of a restoration of Islamic values to the center stage of world events.

Thus, the nation-state has become as normative a structure for Muslims as for non-muslim countries. It embodies little of Islamic ideals for social justice. It projects either tribal stratification or military authoritarianism, or both.

Thus, Islamic Fundamentalism arose as a response to the failure of Muslim nationalisms. Had the transition from dependence to independence worked there would have been no Islamic fundamentalism, or at most, it would have been a modest movement. Instead, independence proved a severe disappointment to most Muslims. The reaction has been for these fundamentalist movements, such as the wahabi in Saudi Arabia, and an offshoot the Taliban in Afghanistan, to attempt to recover what they believed to be the original golden age of Islam.

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Phillips, Kevin: American Theocracy: The Peril and politics of the radical religion. .. (NY: Viking press, 2006)

Definitions:

FUNDAMENTALISM is the affirmation of religious authority as holistic and absolute, admitting of neither criticism nor reduction. It is expressed thru the collective demand of the faith community that specific creedal and ethical dictates derived from scripture be publicly recognized and legally enforced. IT IS AN IDEOLOGY NOT A THEOLOGY.

MODERNISM: is the search for individual autonomy driven by a set of socially encoded values emphasizing change over continuity; quantity over quality; efficient production, power and profit over sympathy for traditional values or vocations, in both the public and private spheres.

Nothing has defined the tone of fundamentalist rhetoric as much as the hatred and Fear of Modernism.

NATIONALISM vs. RELIGION : How can believers preserve their symbolic identity within a public order that is structurally anti-religious? These are genuine contradictions.

Progressive PROTESTANT Patriotism or PPP="America, Love it or leave it"

Efforts exerted within rather than against the framework of U.S institutions.

THE CHRISTIAN RECONSTRUCTIONIST MOVEMENT: Comes out of the Calvinistic tradition but crosses denominational lines in conservative churches.

ALL the biblical laws still apply unless mitigated by later revelation.

JUDAISM: Zionism was one of the most successful nationalist ideologies and led to state of Israel.

Neturei Karta opposes all efforts to develop a civil religion. keeps traditions

Gush Emunim: Must retake all land David once held so the Messiah will come
the Ultra Orthodox are growing in power and numbers and controlling marriages, Burials, and conversions.

ISLAM: With the end of European colonialism, 20th century nationalism produced a huge cleavage in Islam. Those who accommodated to western values and those who opposed them.

Both of these groups were from the urban elite, leaving out the rural, illiterate people.

Islam speaks to every area of life and claims to be universal, but nationalism produced antagonism not only to the west, but to other Muslim countries.

Islamic fundamentalism rose as a response to the failure of Muslim nationalism. This led to attempts to recover the "golden age" by many groups, like the Taliban.

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